

Disambiguating “Proposing Substrate” Across the Trilogy

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This work derives from and formalizes commitments across the CKS theory trilogy: The Instinct/Reasoning Separation Outside the Model (Li, April 2026), Coordination Outside the Model: A Human-Governed Substrate Pattern for AI Systems (Li, April 2026), and Inter-Self Coordination via Shared Substrate / Full Aspect Integration (Li, April 2026). It does not introduce new axioms. Its contribution is to disambiguate proposing substrate as that term is used across the three papers, so that downstream work can trace the component across papers without treating Paper 3's configured extension as a new mechanism.

Abstract

The CKS trilogy names the *proposing substrate* in Paper 2 (B1.15) and extends it in Paper 3 (D2.59). Because the two papers give the component different source content — Paper 2's proposing substrate reads home-generated action-layer records; Paper 3's reads action-layer content that now includes records ingested from inter-Self coordination events — a reader might treat the two as distinct mechanisms. This note formalizes the contrary. The proposing substrate throughout the trilogy is the same LLM-mediated component reading action-layer content and generating structured improvement proposals for governance consideration. Paper 3's extension changes what action-layer content is available and makes optional governance configuration available for recognizing inter-Self provenance. The mechanism does not change; configuration expands what it surfaces. This note states the Paper 1 governance basis, the Paper 2 specification, the Paper 3 extension, the disambiguation boundary, and the prior-art closure.

1. The Concept and the Ambiguity Risk

The proposing substrate is the component within the action-feedback evolution mechanism responsible for converting accumulated operational records into governance-relevant improvement proposals. It reads action-layer content and generates structured proposals that governance can review and, if approved, feed into directed selection for substrate change.

Paper 2 names and specifies the component. Paper 3 extends it by expanding the source of action-layer content the component reads and by making optional configuration available for recognizing inter-Self provenance in that content.

The ambiguity risk: because Paper 3 introduces governance configuration for the proposing substrate that Paper 2 does not describe, a reader might treat Paper 3's configured proposing substrate as a new mechanism specialized for inter-Self coordination, rather than as an extension of the Paper 2 component. That reading would allow an adversary to claim novelty for what is architecturally the Paper 2 mechanism with governance-authored orchestration rules added. This

note forecloses that reading.

2. Paper 1: The Governance Basis

Paper 1 does not name the proposing substrate as a component. It establishes the architectural basis on which the proposing substrate operates through Claim 4 Property A: the LLM operates as a substrate mediator, reading substrate content and producing governance-relevant outputs under human-authored orchestration rules. The proposing substrate is a specific instantiation of that capability in which the substrate content being read is action-layer content and the governance-relevant output is an improvement proposal.

Paper 1's authority-vs-labor distinction (§3.3) further establishes that the labor of drafting proposals may be performed by the LLM under human direction while authority over the proposal-and-acceptance process remains with humans. This is what makes the proposing substrate compatible with governance at scale: the LLM generates proposals; humans hold authority over acceptance and feed into directed selection.

Paper 1 provides the authority for the proposing substrate to operate. It does not name the component.

3. Paper 2: The Named Component (B1.15)

Paper 2 names and specifies the proposing substrate as a distinct component within action-feedback evolution (B1.15): an LLM-mediated substrate component that reads home action-layer content and generates structured improvement proposals for home governance consideration. Approved proposals feed into directed selection, producing DNA-layer changes. The component operates under human-authored orchestration rules specifying what kinds of proposals to generate and how they should be structured.

Four properties characterize the Paper 2 proposing substrate. *Source content*: home action-layer records — at Paper 2 scope, exclusively home-generated. *Output*: structured improvement proposals with sufficient specificity for governance to evaluate. *Governance pathway*: proposals go to home governance for review; governance holds authority over acceptance; the component does not self-authorize any substrate change. *Orchestration*: the component's behavior is governed by human-authored orchestration rules that are themselves substrate content under the authority architecture they instantiate.

The proposing substrate at Paper 2 scope is a well-bounded component. Its source, output, governance pathway, and operation under orchestration rules are all specified.

4. Paper 3: Same Component, Expanded Source, Optional Configuration (D2.59)

Paper 3 extends the proposing substrate through D2.59 along two axes.

First axis: expanded source content. At Paper 3 scope, action-layer content includes records ingested from inter-Self coordination events through the action-feedback locus. The proposing substrate reads them because it reads action-layer content. No reconfiguration is required. The default mode is the same-pipeline mode: FAI-origin action-layer records are processed identically to

home-generated records.

Default mode is Paper 3-compliant. An organization participating in inter-Self coordination events does not need to configure its proposing substrate for FAI-origin awareness to comply with Paper 3's architecture.

Second axis: optional governance configuration. Paper 3 specifies three configurations governance may author to enable inter-Self awareness in the proposing substrate's output.

Configuration A directs the proposing substrate to flag proposals derived from FAI-origin records distinctly — marking them with provenance metadata so that governance can see which proposals draw on inter-Self experience versus home-only experience.

Configuration B directs the proposing substrate to generate comparative proposals for competition-format inter-Self coordination events — proposals that explicitly compare the Self's operational patterns against what was observed in the shared substrate, surfacing performance differentials as structured improvement intelligence. Configuration B is the strategically most important of the three. Competition-format events exist specifically to generate comparative performance data; that data's primary value is the inter-Self comparison it contains. Without Configuration B, competition-event action-layer records enter the standard pipeline and produce proposals about home operations, but the comparative dimension is not surfaced as comparative intelligence. Configuration B is what makes competition-event outputs actionable as the governance improvement intelligence those events are designed to produce.

Configuration C directs the proposing substrate to specifically process conflict carry-through annotations — records that entered the home action layer flagged as originating in preserved inter-Self conflicts — and generate proposals specifically addressed to the conflict boundaries those annotations identify.

All three configurations are authored governance content: orchestration rules specifying what the proposing substrate looks for and how it structures its output. The component's mechanism is unchanged.

5. The Disambiguation

The proposing substrate throughout the trilogy refers to the same LLM-mediated improvement proposal generator. The differences across papers are differences in source content and in optional governance configuration — not differences in mechanism.

Paper 2 scope: source is home-generated action-layer records only; no FAI-origin records exist; no inter-Self provenance configuration is relevant.

Paper 3 scope, default mode: source is home action-layer records including FAI-origin records ingested through the action-feedback locus; the component processes all records identically; no configuration is required; default mode is Paper 3-compliant.

Paper 3 scope, configured mode: governance has authored one or more of Configurations A, B, or C; the component recognizes FAI-origin provenance and generates proposals with inter-Self

awareness; configured mode is a governance quality enhancement above the compliance baseline.

These are not three different components. They are one component — specified in Paper 2, operating at Paper 3 scope with an expanded action-layer source, optionally configured by governance for inter-Self awareness. The architectural invariants that define the component hold at all three scopes: LLM-mediated, reads action layer, generates structured proposals, routes to governance, governed by human-authored orchestration rules.

The adversary exploitation risk this disambiguation forecloses: claiming that Paper 3's configured proposing substrate — particularly the three named configurations — is a novel mechanism for inter-Self governance intelligence generation, independent of Paper 2's proposal-and-acceptance machinery. That claim fails because the configurations are orchestration rules authored within Paper 2's proposal-and-acceptance framework. The mechanism is Paper 2's. The configurations are human-authored governance content within that mechanism.

6. Prior-Art Closure

Any system implementing an LLM-mediated component that reads action-layer content (including FAI-origin records) and generates structured improvement proposals for governance review — with optional governance-authored configuration for provenance-aware proposal generation — is implementing the Paper 2 proposing substrate (B1.15) at Paper 3 scope (D2.59). The component is fully specified in Paper 2. Paper 3 adds one governance quality extension: Configurations A, B, and C for organizations wanting inter-Self awareness in their proposal generation. Those configurations are authored orchestration content within the Paper 2 mechanism. Prior-art coverage for the configured proposing substrate is provided jointly by the Paper 2 component specification and Paper 3's treatment of governance-authored configuration as substrate content.

Source Papers

Li, W. (2026). *The Instinct/Reasoning Separation Outside the Model*. April 2026. ORCID: 0009-0004-8065-3235.

Li, W. (2026). *Coordination Outside the Model: A Human-Governed Substrate Pattern for AI Systems*. April 2026. ORCID: 0009-0004-8065-3235.

Li, W. (2026). *Inter-Self Coordination via Shared Substrate / Full Aspect Integration*. April 2026. ORCID: 0009-0004-8065-3235.

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